Beyond GDP:
Exploring Sustainable Wellbeing

How does economic wealth relate to wellbeing, and does greater wealth necessarily lead to more sustainable wellbeing?

EPPS 6356: Data Visualization
Assignment7: Hackathon 2.0

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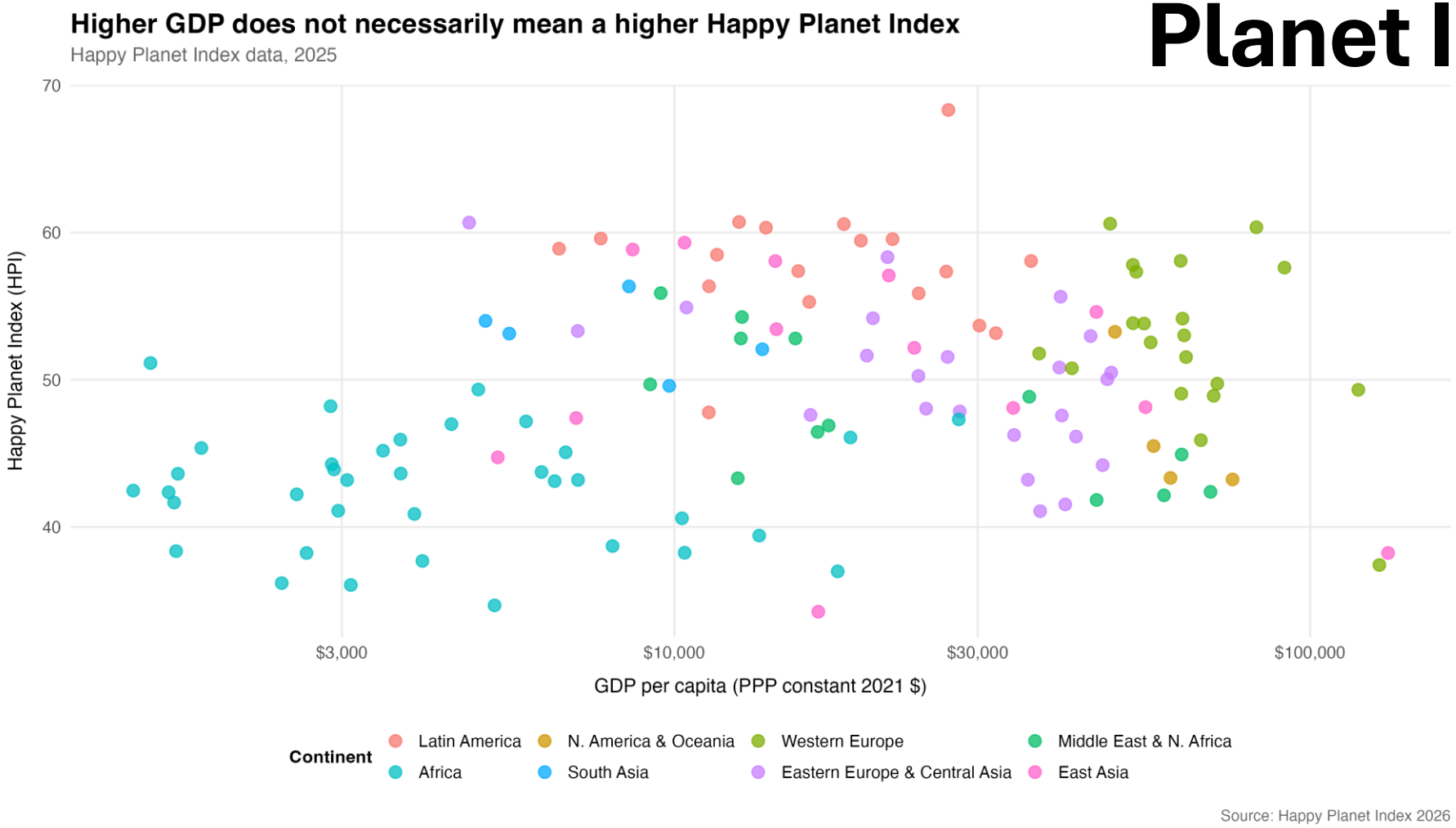
Data:
Measuring Wellbeing Beyond GDP

- **Source:** Happy Planet Index 2026 public dataset
- **Unit of analysis:** Country
- **Countries:** 132
- **Year:** 2025 *(GDP per capita uses 2024 values)*

- **Key Variables**:
  GDP per capita → Economic wealth
  Life satisfaction → Subjective wellbeing
  Ecological footprint → Environmental resource use
  HPI → Sustainable wellbeing

Question: Does greater economic wealth also mean greater sustainable wellbeing?

Chart 9. GDP and Happy Planet Index: 2025

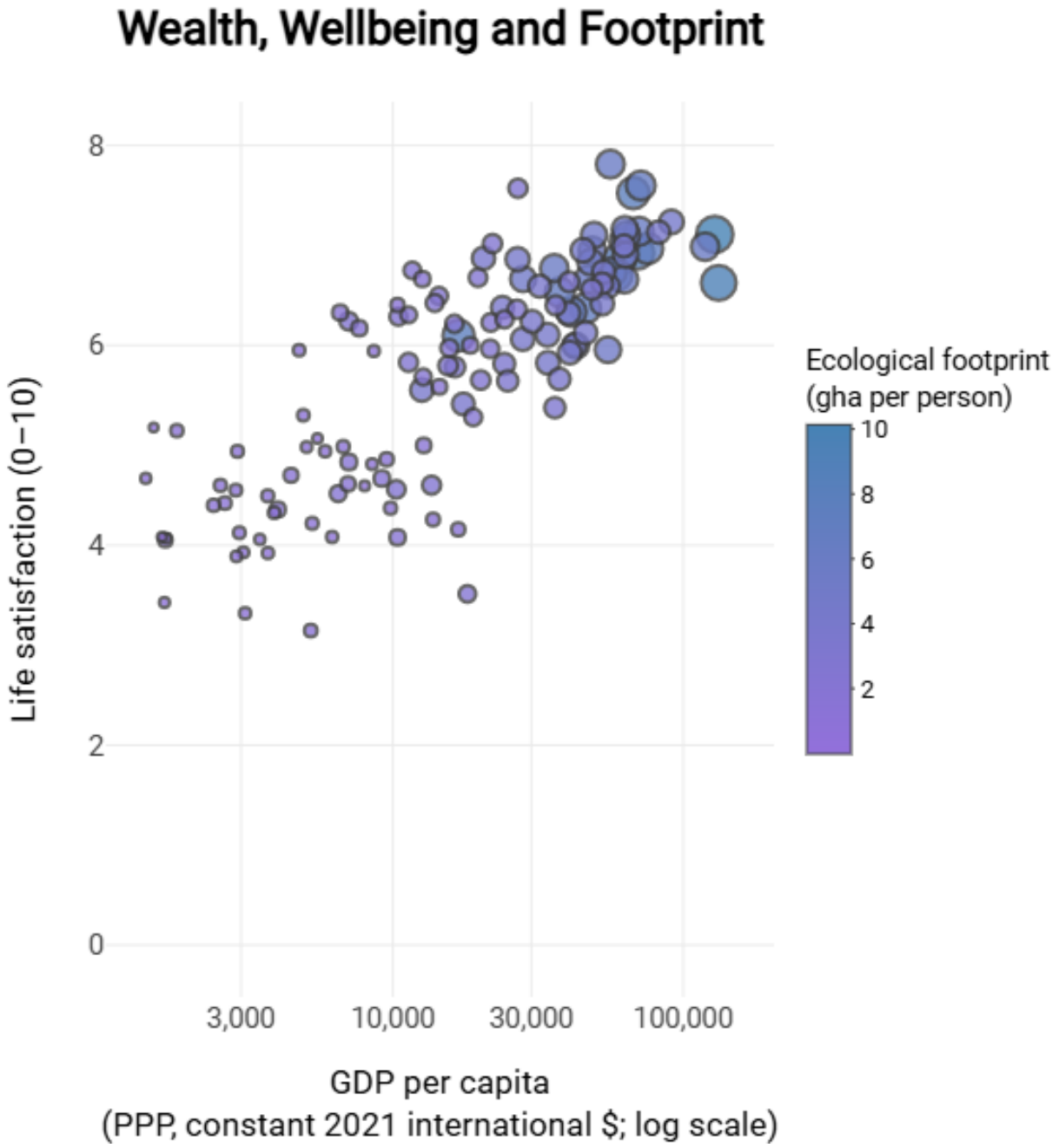


Source: Happy Planet Index 2026

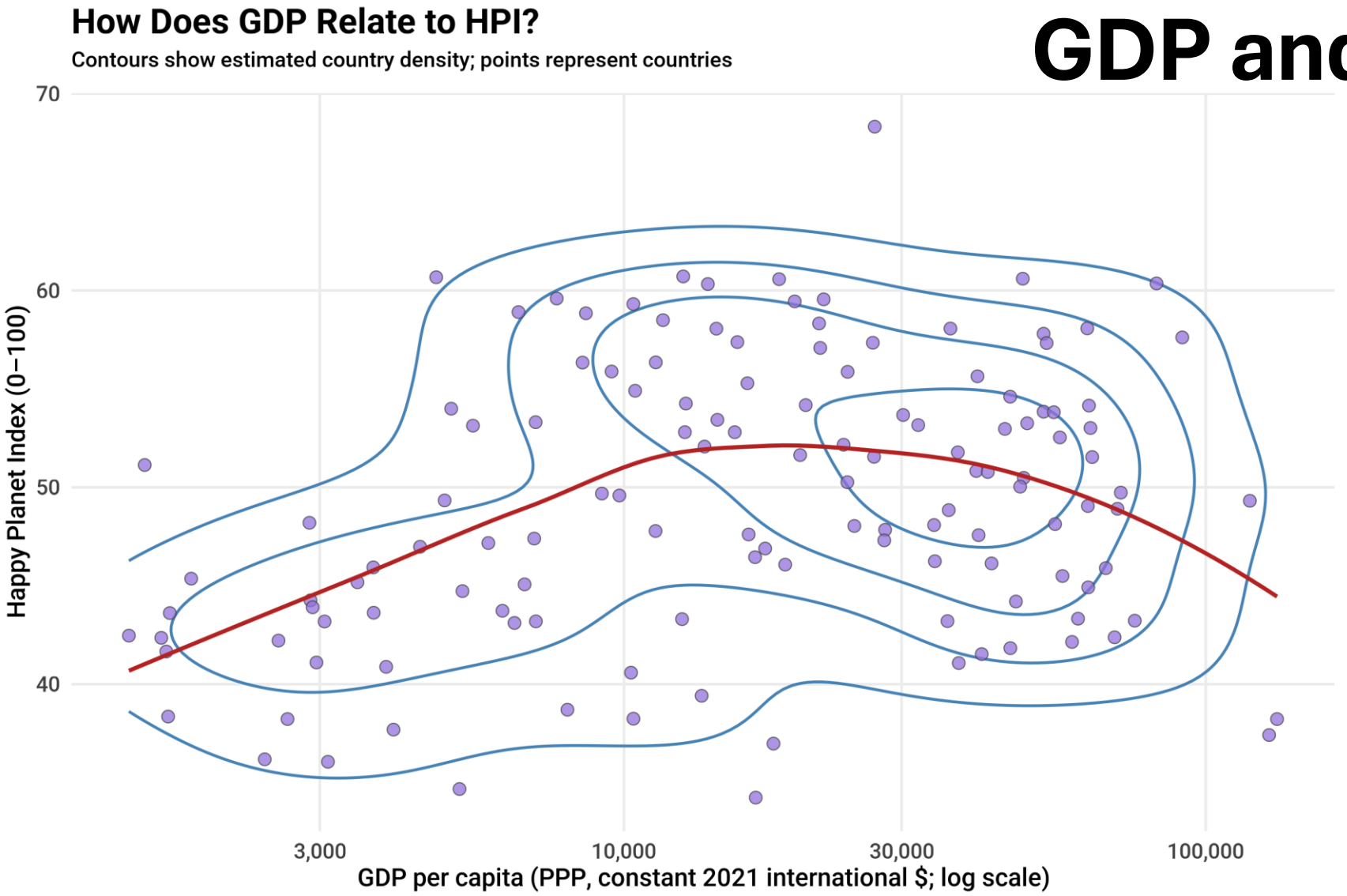
- GDP alone does not explain differences in HPI.
- Countries with similar income levels can still differ substantially in sustainable wellbeing.

Chart 18. Wealth, Wellbeing and Footprint: 2025

- Life satisfaction generally increases with GDP per capita.
- However, wealthier countries also tend to have larger ecological footprints.
- Similar levels of life satisfaction can come with very different environmental costs.



Additional Chart. GDP and Happy Planet Index: 2025



Source: Happy Planet Index. 2025 data; GDP uses 2024 values.

- Contours show where countries are concentrated in the GDP–HPI distribution.
- HPI tends to rise with GDP at lower income levels, then levels off and declines at higher income levels.
- Greater wealth does not consistently correspond to greater sustainable wellbeing.

Why this chart? It reveals the overall shape and concentration of the GDP–HPI relationship

Conclusion: Beyond GDP

Conclusion

- Economic wealth is associated with higher life satisfaction.
- Higher wealth often comes with a larger ecological footprint.
- GDP alone does not fully capture sustainable wellbeing.

GDP tells only part of the story.

Links

- GitHub
- Interactive App
- Team Website